The Incantation for Remembering Past Births

Toh 889 · Derge Kangyur

The Heart of Sukhāvatī, known in Tibetan as Dewachen gyi Nyingpo and likely corresponding to a Sanskrit title such as Sukhāvatīhṛdaya, is a brief incantation text, or dhāraṇī, centered on the noble bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara. It opens with homage to the Buddha, the Dharma, the Saṅgha, and Avalokiteśvara, then presents a short mantra that the reciter asks to be accomplished on their behalf. It promises two benefits to anyone who recites it: they will remember their births for a hundred thousand lifetimes, and after death they will be reborn in Sukhāvatī, the pure land of bliss. The work is Toh 889 in the Kangyur, where it belongs among the dhāraṇī texts, the short spells and incantations preserved alongside the tantric scriptures.

Homage to the Buddha. Homage to the Dharma. Homage to the Saṅgha. Homage to the noble Avalokiteśvara, the bodhisattva, the great being. Having paid homage to them, I take up this incantation: may this incantation be accomplished for me.

tadyathā hana hana svāni navasāni jvala jvalane cala calane purbo yogamanusmara phaṭ mahāhataya svāhā

Whoever recites this incantation will remember their births for a hundred thousand lifetimes. And after dying and passing on from here, they will be born in the world of Sukhāvatī.

This completes the Heart of Sukhāvatī.

Translator's Notes

• The Tibetan here is bde ldan, "possessing bliss," rather than the more usual bde ba can. It is taken as a rendering of Sukhāvatī, the pure land of Amitābha. The phrase rig pa 'di 'dzin gyis is read as the reciter's declaration, "I take up this incantation," which leads into the wish that follows.

Colophon

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Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.